

BLENDING TEAS

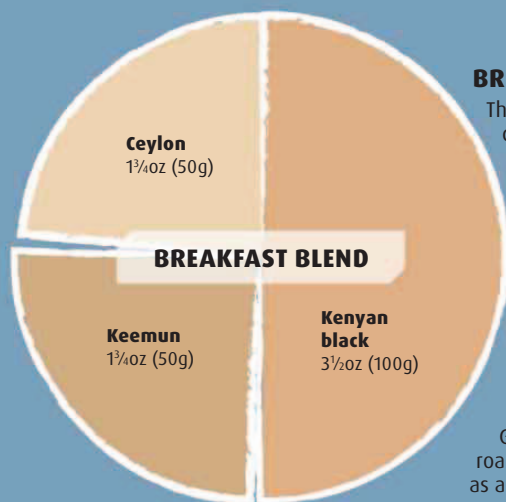
The practice of blending began 400 years ago in the Fujian province of China, when loose-leaf tea replaced the solid, hard-to-blend brick tea, and jasmine and other flowers were added to enhance flavor and fragrance. While the classic blends remain popular, there are new blending styles that experiment with fruit and flowers. Practice the art of blending your own tea with these recipes.

There are two methods of blending tea: commercial blending and signature blending. Commercial blending involves using as many as 30–40 teas of various origins to create a consistent taste from season to season for the commercial tea bag industry. Master blenders taste hundreds of teas daily from all the tea-growing regions to create a dependable blend. The goal is to create the same flavors today that you had last year and the year before.

Signature blending, on the other hand, involves blending together several teas of different origins, usually with inclusions such as dried fruits, spices, or flowers. In a commercial kitchen, additional flavors and essences are usually sprayed on the tea leaves and they are placed in a blending drum for mixing, but you can blend your ingredients at home by stirring together in a bowl. All recipes are based on creating 7oz (200g) of blended tea.

CLASSIC BLENDS

Most tea lovers are familiar with these blends, and some of these classics have endured for centuries. Other than Genmaicha, all can be served with milk. Try the blend recipes given below, or experiment with the proportions to come up with your own signature blend.



BREAKFAST BLEND

There are many versions of this classic morning blend. The most common is English Breakfast, which features teas from India, Sri Lanka, and Kenya in varying proportions. Irish Breakfast uses Assam in its blend, and is therefore quite robust. Breakfast blends were often tailored to accommodate the hardness or softness of the water in the areas they were created for. Blend recipes are a closely guarded secret, and no tea company of repute will give theirs away.

GENMAICHA

Known as the “people’s tea” in Japan, Genmaicha consists of Sencha leaves and roasted rice, which was traditionally added as a filler to make the tea more affordable, but is now appreciated for its flavor. Occasionally, there are a few grains of popped rice in the blend, which is why it is also called “popcorn” tea. Here’s an easy recipe to make your own rice for Genmaicha. Rinse short-grain white rice, then dry-fry on low heat in a cast-iron frying pan for 10–15 minutes until the rice is golden. When the grains have cooled, mix them with the Japanese Sencha.

